

STD IX
ENGLISH NOTES
On Killing A Tree (BEEHIVE)

Q1 Can 'a single jab of the knife' kill a tree? Why not?

Answer: 'A single jab of the knife' cannot kill a tree. The tree has grown consuming the earth, feeding on its crust, absorbing the sunlight, air, and water for years.

Q2 What is the meaning of 'bleeding bark'? What makes it bleed?

Answer: 'Bleeding bark' refers to the jab on the bark of the tree caused by the knife/axe. The jab inflicted by man causes the bark to ooze sap from the bark of the tree which is personified as the wound that bleeds blood.

Q3. The poet says "No" in the beginning of the third stanza. What does he mean by this?

Answer: The Poet stresses that simply jabbing the tree with a knife or hacking it will not kill it. It is too strong and resilient to die so easily. Man will have to adopt extreme measures to destroy it completely.

Q4. What is the meaning of "anchoring earth" and "earth cave"?

Answer: The tree tall and firmly fixed because of its roots that have grown deeply into the earth, feeding on its crust and becoming stronger and sturdy. 'The earth cave' is the

space deep inside the ground where the roots have lodged and fixed the tree firmly and deeply.

Q5. What does he mean by “the strength of the tree exposed”?

Answer: “Strength of the tree” refers to the roots of the tree which is the life support system of the tree, as the roots fix the tree firmly to the ground and provides all the nourishment required for its growth from the soil. Therefore, when the roots are pulled out, the heart of the tree or its strength is exposed.

Q6. What finally kills the tree?

Answer: The tree is finally killed when its source is exposed into the open. Scorching and choking it in sun and air. Browning, hardening, twisting and withering. Thus killing it.

Value Based Question:

What Is the Message of the poem ‘On killing a Tree’?

The poem conveys the message that trees are living beings just like any other form of life. They have strong survival instinct and can withstand any assault trauma or crisis. It is not easy to kill them, for they have a never say die attitude to life. Every time they are attacked, injured or scraped, they heal themselves and regain their glory. The poet applauds their resilience and sturdiness. However, if they are uprooted and left in the air and sun. They do not survive. One wonders if human beings have such kind of attitude towards life.

It is also a scathing criticism of human callousness and cruelty in chopping down trees in the name of urbanisation,

modernisation and industrialisation. It is a passionate appeal not to cut trees.